

The sweet satisfaction of *sangharsh*

Between CES, Startup India and this whole Free Basics fracas, I hardly got time to do anything else this month. In fact, in hindsight I can safely say this was an extraordinarily busy issue. To blow off some steam I figured I'll build myself a new PC. It may sound odd to some of you, and believe me this is not a humblebrag or an attempt at upping my geek cred, but I genuinely find the activity quite meditative. I take my time with it, too. Apply the perfect amount of thermal paste, get the wire management exactly right, screw those HDDs properly in their racks – you know, the little things.

Now in an ideal world, tech is supposed to come into our lives and make things better. But sometimes things just don't pan out the way you want. With this new PC, I remembered I had an old Windows 8 Pro upgrade key from 2013 with me that I never ended up using. So I thought why not install Windows 8 Pro and use the key, upgrade to Windows 8.1 and then eventually move up to Windows 10. Simple enough, right? All it needed was a night's worth of downloads and a couple of restarts at the most. Or so I thought.

Microsoft had other plans for me.

First, the upgrade key wouldn't work on a fresh install. I clean installed Windows 7 and proceeded to upgrade to 8 Pro. So far so good. Now came the tricky part. As it turns out the upgrade to 8.1 doesn't come through Windows update the way it normally should. Instead you need to do it via the Windows Store for some unfathomable reason. No big deal. Let's upgrade!

Not so fast there. Windows wanted my 8 Pro installation to be up to date before the 8.1 upgrade became available in the store. After downloading 198 important updates the system proceeded to restart. Only a handful of updates installed successfully and the rest failed. After trying multiple times with each download and restart cycle lasting about two hours because of the sheer number of updates, I finally searched for a solution on the official forums. Turns out this "Failure configuring Windows updates. Reverting changes" error was a known issue. Microsoft even released a separate tool called the "Windows Update

Troubleshooter" to fix it. To cut a long story short, after conjuring up multiple conspiracy theories about Microsoft's dark side, I eventually got hold of a batch file from tech support and the updates proceeded smoothly. Ahh I can still feel the endorphin release when finally that Windows 10 start screen greeted me.

There is definitely a great deal of joy to be derived from putting things together with your bare hands. Similarly there is also a great deal of satisfaction that comes from having struggled to get something working and then finally enjoying its benefits.

Could there be some primal lizard-brain reward-loop at work here? Possibly. I distinctly remember experiencing similar joy having tamed a particularly finicky X58 motherboard a couple of years ago. That board drove me up the wall. It was so moody that I actually authored an in-house guide to making it work. Guess what I titled it? Yup "*sangharsh*". Forgive me but with my limited vocabulary in both languages I somehow felt "struggle" isn't a perfect substitute for "*sangharsh*". Struggle seemed to me to be the act of toiling irrespective of reward while *sangharsh* has a connotation that is akin to fighting the good fight towards a positive outcome.

Would I ever want my things to "just work" the way devices and services within some ecosystems are purported to function? Yes definitely, I'm not a masochist. For example with my TV viewing experience I want all my streaming and connected devices to just enable the lazy lout within me to revel blissfully in audio-visual rapture.

But a little bit of tweaking, tinkering and *sangharsh* just makes my tech-life all that much more lively.

How do you like your tech? Working straight out of the box, or with a little err...character? 



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